

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Source: Our World in Data / IHME Global Burden of Disease, 2023

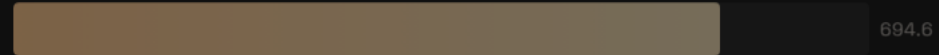


Depression and Anxiety Dominate Disease Burden



Near-Equal Global Burden: Depression & Anxiety

Depressive Disorders



Anxiety Disorders



Schizophrenia & Bipolar: Lower Prevalence, High Individual Impact



While population-level burden is lower than depression/anxiety, individual severity and disability are high. Schizophrenia contributes **210.2 DALYs per 100,000** — reflecting the severe disability associated with the condition.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality



Stigma

Many feel
uncomfortable
disclosing symptoms



Access

Treatment often
lacking, especially in
low-income settings



Quality

Even where available,
care may be
inadequate



Underreporting

True prevalence likely
higher than reported

Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced — yet many people do not receive adequate care due to stigma, access barriers, and quality gaps.



How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings



Religious/Spiritual

Prevalent across many regions worldwide



Family & Friends

Widely reported coping mechanism

Responses vary widely across countries and cultures. Policy interventions must account for these differences rather than applying a one-size-fits-all approach.



Key Takeaways for Policy & Planning

- Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs (~690 per 100K each), nearly equal in magnitude
- Schizophrenia carries disproportionate individual burden (210.2 DALYs) relative to its prevalence
- Treatment exists but access and quality remain inadequate — the true burden is likely underestimated
- Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data collection
- Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions

